

Foucault on Power, Ideology and Disciplinary Society.

Sarah Kember on medical scans of pregnant women:



The scanning process eliminates the mother's body from view and the doctor has direct access to the image of the foetus.

Kember, S. 1998 *Virtual Anxiety* (Manchester University Press).

Q. What has this got to do with Foucault?

- *A. It raises the question of power and its relation to knowledge?*
- How?
- Why?

Regarding scans

- Is it a good thing that doctors can “visualize” a foetus?
- Could this lead to the woman being viewed as unimportant? (Her body as a problem to be overcome?)
- The answer to both of these questions could be “yes”

The question of ideology

- Are doctors part of a patriarchal system which denies or ignores women's issues and bodies?
- This is not exactly untrue.
- Think about what areas of medicine are seen as more important/valid or worthy of research (and research money)
- But can we use such notions of ideology to fully understand how **power** operates in modernity?
- **“It is both much more and much less than ideology.” (Foucault: 1980: *Power/Knowledge*: 102)**

What is power?

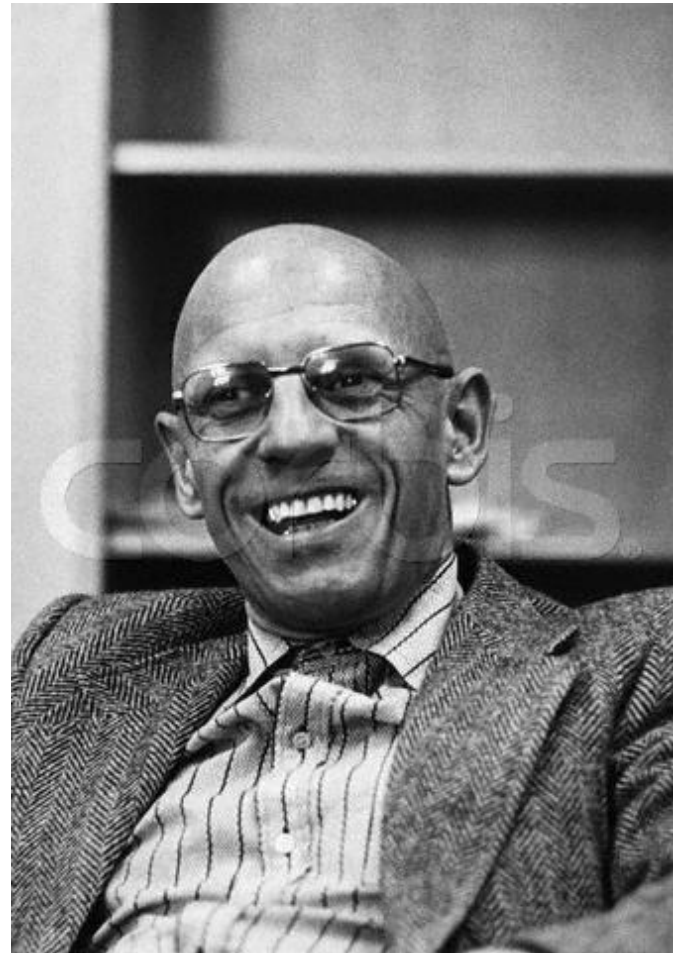
- Can we provide a definition?...
- “The capacity to make someone do something or to influence the behaviour of someone else.”
- This is the usual way of thinking about power.
- Foucault says that this is only half the story
- If we want to know what power is, then we need to understand **HOW** power relations operate in society.

Michel Foucault (1926-1984)

- French Theorist –
1926-1984

Famous for his ideas on
power.

- The work of Foucault has influenced many of the people we will be looking at this term who write about sexuality/race/gender etc.
- This is why it is important to understand his ideas before we look in these in more detail.



Foucault says that how power operates has changed...

- Prior to the 19th century, power in society operated in a different way.
- At the beginning of his book *Discipline and Punish* he gives a graphic description of how someone who tried to kill a king was treated
- They were tried, found guilty and then they were tortured and subjected to a lengthy procedure physical punishment until they died.
- The point, Foucault argues, was to show the power of the monarch through the abuse of the body of the criminal.
- This is an example of what Foucault calls “sovereign” power
- It relied upon physical force and coercion and it was “spectacular” (it needed to be seen to be done).
- Since the 19th century, in “modern” Western society, there has been a shift in HOW power operates.
- Rather than using force (corporal or capital punishment, flogging etc.), power in modern society is what Foucault calls ***Disciplinary***

Disciplinary Power

- The word “discipline” has a range of applications and connotations.
- Foucault makes use of these
- Sociology is a discipline
- You need discipline to learn a musical instrument
- Some people discipline their dogs
- Or children
- Discipline seems to involve both training and changing someone (or something’s behaviour)
- It is thus a question of power

More on Disciplinary Power

- A variety of techniques are used in such as discipline
- For example - In schools – registers, progress reports, school photos, records of achievement, testing, key stages...
- Are all used learn more about each child but also as a subtle form of discipline
- This disciplinary form of power is not just present in schools but throughout society (as we will see).
- Power is not about the state or the powerful simply stopping us doing things
- Power is subtle
- It is everywhere
- It points out what is normal and invites us to behave in a similar way, to judge ourselves in relation to this “norm”
- Contemporary society is a ‘disciplinary society’



For example:

- ‘We are used to thinking of power as what presses on the subject from the outside [...] But if [...] we understand power as *forming* the subject as well as providing the very condition of its existence [...] then power is not simply what we oppose, but also, in a strong sense, what we depend on for our existence and what we harbour and preserve in the beings that we are.’ (Butler, 1997: 1-2). (From *The Psychic Life of Power*)

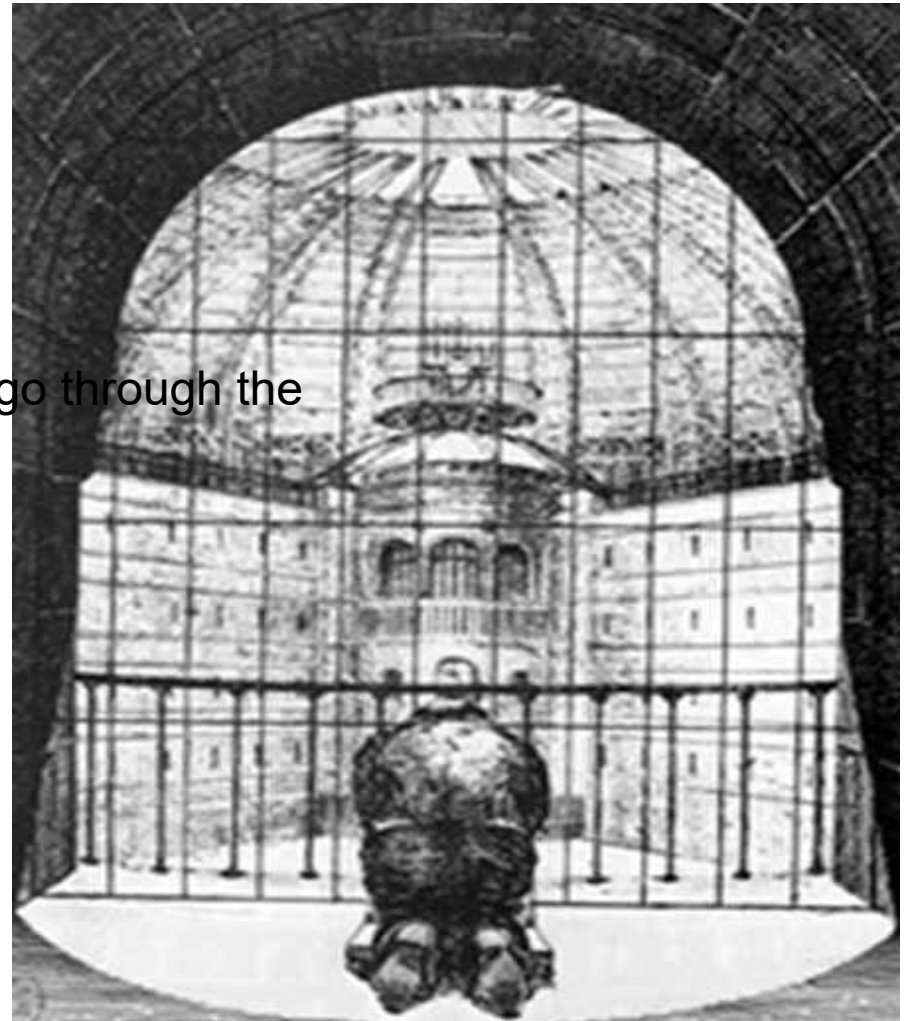
Power is not just repressive - Power is productive

- What does it produce?
- Foucault says that in the 19th century – new kinds of people (new kinds of subjects) were **created** or **produced** through the creation of new institutions such as schools, prisons, psychiatric hospitals etc.

For example, the creation/production of the modern prisoner....

Treating Humans as both Subjects and Objects -*Discipline and Punish*

- The prisoner is formed as a new kind of object
- This object is the modern *subject*
- The image of the Panopticon
- This was an ideal of a prison
- It had a central watchtower to go through the
- A light shone out from this tower into the cells of the prisoners.
- They could not look back into the tower
- But they could be observed/monitored/continually



The Panopticon as a model of modernity?

- The modern prison is designed not to physically punish(as was the case with sovereign power)
- The aim is to reform or rehabilitate
- The panopticon encourages the prisoner to behave as if they are continually under surveillance
- They begin to “inspect” or monitor their own behaviour
- **This opens up an interiority into which both the prison guard and the inmate can ‘look’.**
- **The Panopticon is where the exercise of power produces the formation of the conscience (of the inmate)**
- **Power is linked to visibility and vision and to knowledge**



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Disciplinary Power

- If power 'shouted at us' all the time we would notice it
- Rather, it invites and incites us to behave in certain ways
- We discipline ourselves! We self-regulate!

To Read Later

- **“This form of power applies itself to immediate everyday life which categorizes the individual, marks him by his own individuality, attaches him to his identity, imposes a law of truth on him which he must recognize and which others must recognize in him. It is a form of power which makes individuals subjects.” [Sic!!!] (Foucault: 1982: *The Subject and Power*: 212)**

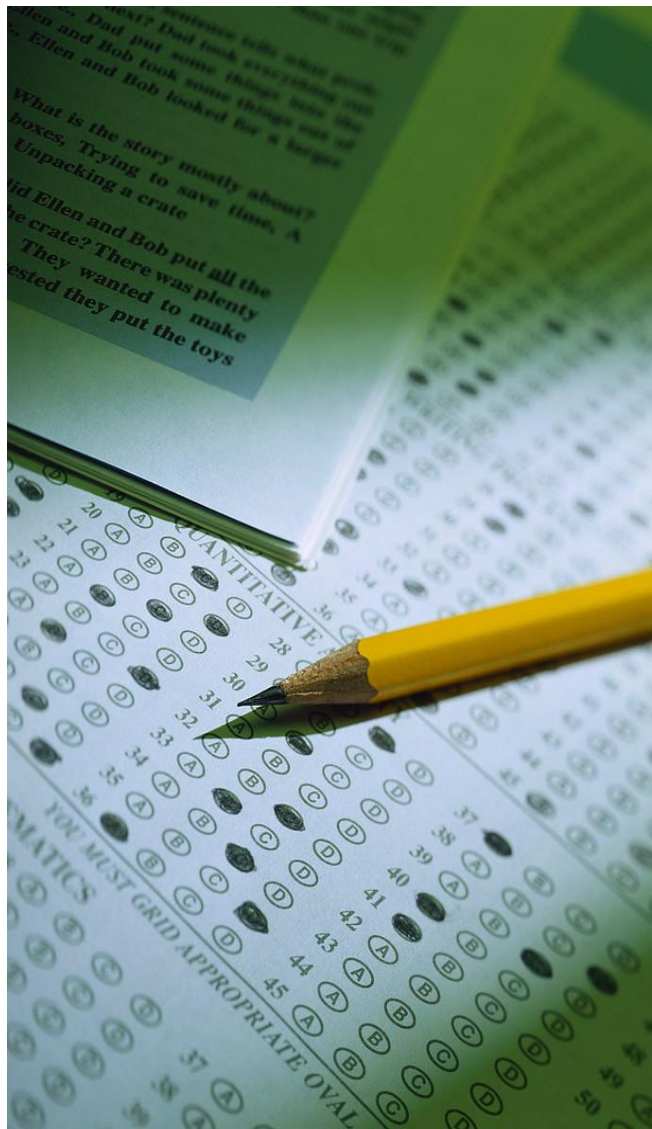
3 Aspects of Discipline

1) Hierarchical Observation

Observers or monitors inspect from a distance and are themselves unobserved and are not judged

2) Examination

Where we are tested, where we are checked to see how we fit in with the rest. To see how far we fit in with or deviate from the 'Norm'



3rd aspect of Discipline

3) Normalizing Judgement

Previous forms of discipline simply stated what was forbidden and what was allowed. The revolution in the development of disciplinary society is that it introduces the idea of what is 'normal'.

Disciplinary society operates both by making us homogenized – we must all conform to norms, to the normal

Disciplinary society also operates by making us take on responsibility as individuals for matching up to norms!

'Am I different from the rest?' 'Is everyone like me?' 'Am I a good friend?'. Hence the prevalence of questionnaires etc.

19th century and the invention of “the normal”

- Is the concept of the “normal” one of the most insidious of all concepts of modernity?

Q. What Does Disciplinary Power Produce? A. Docile Bodies

- Foucault says that disciplinary society is one in which we are not forbidden to do things so much as disciplined into behaving in certain ways.
- Schools do this, doctors do this, religion does this, the workplace does this.
- They all try to create us as 'docile bodies' – ones which are passive and which regulate themselves according to the normalizing judgements of society
- Such docile bodies fit well into the modern capitalist economy and work well in factories and offices. They question little and behave well. And don't resist. Let alone revolt. The bourgeoisie has won!

“It is our duty to keep ourselves healthy”

- This may seem obvious but what power mechanisms help support such a statement?
 - ‘it is the duty of government to make us reduce our salt level’
 - we feel bad if we do not eat 5 portions of fruit/veg per day
 - the government must stop obese children

Susan Bordo – ‘Reading the Slender Body’ (1992).

- In the late 19th century certain body images were seen as ‘good’.

For men:

- Being ‘plump’ showed you were successful (‘good’)
- Having muscles was seen as working-class (‘bad’)
- For women:
 - pale skin was seen as good, as it meant that you did not have to work in the fields

All of these were one kind of normalizing judgement



More recent changes

- Bordo says 30 years ago we were concerned with weight- how heavy we are:

- We were encouraged to diet, 'fight the flab',
Nowadays, we have to be 'slender'.

Adverts talk of being in trim, well-toned, well-defined.

We have to control our bodies

Our body parts are in revolt - thighs, stomach, upper arms, calves

There has been a change in the kinds of normalizing judgements but they are still normalizing. In fact they are more intrusive into the very insides of our bodies.

- Images of success in the 20th century are very different from those of the 19th century. No longer is plumpness as sign of wealth and success. Being fat is equated with being lazy. Of not caring. Of being a failure.
- So we have to produce our bodies as slender, muscular etc. to show that we are successful
- More demands are made on women than men in terms of them producing themselves as 'normal'
- Think of the rise in gym membership.
- In the City of London (banks etc.) it is important to 'work-out' to go to the gym, to show you 'mean business' in both your personal and professional life.
- This is what Foucault means when he talks of the intersections of power, the body, discipline and self-regulation. They are linked to what is regarded as normal. And we are all subject to normalizing judgements.

- “Self-management in consumer culture...becomes more elusive as it becomes more pressing...Between the media images of self-containment and self-mastery and the reality of constant everyday stress...lies the chasm that produces bodies habituated to self-monitoring and self-normalization” (Bordo, 1992: 202-3)



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365 COOL HEALTH,
FITNESS,
SEX & NUTRITION TIPS

THE
EASY WAY TO
**HARD
ABS!**
p.48

**YOUR
BEST
BODY
EVER!**
GET IT NOW!
KEEP IT
FOREVER!

The Men's Health Guy

**Taylor
Kitsch**

HOW HE
MUSCLED UP
FOR FRIDAY
NIGHT LIGHTS



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- - We live in a consumer society – one which runs on us drinking coffee, eating cakes, take-away food etc.

But we have to produce ourselves as normal individuals, in control of ourselves – and this means being in control of our bodies!

This means power operates more subtly but more closely in the regulation of women's bodies with regard to normalizing judgements.

Foucault's work on power can help us understand this situation better/more accurately.

- I won't have time to go through the following slides but I have put them here so you can use them if you want to for your next essay.
- Or exam.

Traditional Ways of Looking at Power

Liberal/Enlightenment views on the State and the Individual ...

- Power is a thing
- Specific people possess power
- Power is dangerous as it limits freedom
- This suggests that power can be seized, that power can corrupt.
- First-wave feminists would say that power needs to be shared equally between men and women.

Traditional Marxist conceptions of power

- Power is solely related to the ownership of the means of production
- Power is in the hands of a small, wealthy minority
- Ideology is one main tool by which power is exercised over the working-class in capitalist societies
- The proletariat need to “discover” their own power and overthrow the current power arrangements of the bourgeoisie.
- Feminist Marxists would say that there is a gender element to this.

- **“Power in Western capitalism was denounced by the Marxists as class domination; but the mechanics of power themselves were never analysed.” (Foucault: 1980: *Power/Knowledge*: 116)**
- **We need to look at HOW power operates**

Power is not just repressive but productive

- **“We should not forget that...the police force was not only invented for maintaining law and order, nor for assisting governments in their struggle against their enemies, but for assuring urban supplies, hygiene, health”. (Foucault: 1982: *The Subject and Power*: 215)**



And we can return to the start...

